Answering 12-Mark Questions

Exam code: 9BS0

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How do I answer an Edexcel A level Business 12-mark question?

- These questions appear in all three exam papers
- Two marks are available for knowledge, two for application, four for analysis and four for evaluation.

Suggested structure

- Key business skills are highlighted

Knowledge Application Analysis Evaluation

Step 1
• Start off by **showing some knowledge; defining a key term or using a business concept is good way to do this**   ○ This will secure some Level 1 knowledge marks and can help you focus your response
Traffic Light Lollies have low sales in a low-growth market. They could, therefore, be considered to be a 'dog' product in Bon Bons' product portfolio. Defining the nature of the product shows knowledge
Step 2

• In the next paragraph, you should start your analysis by **making a strong point**
  ○ Support it with some relevant **context** from the stimulus material
  ▪ Quoting some data, including a calculation, or remarking on a key business feature or trend are good ways to do this
  ○ Develop a chain of reasoning that develops the point logically. The X→Y→Z approach is a good way to build a coherent chain:

Help me understand

Stuck on something?
Ask questions and get help with exactly what you're revising.
Got it

effectively. For example:

- E.g. X_1 and X_2 lead to Y, which results in Z ***or*** X leads to Y_1 and/or Y_2, which results in Z ***or*** X leads to Y, which results in Z_1 and/or Z_2

Bon Bon's may continue to sell Traffic Light lollies because a small number of customers continue to buy them. Sales in tourist attractions may be low. As long as they cover the costs of producing the lollies, Bon Bon's should continue to sell them as the revenue can contribute to covering fixed costs.

A clear starting point

Some context

Brief but effective reasoning

Step 3

- In the next paragraph, you need to show balance by **providing a counterpoint**
  - Make a logical, relevant counterpoint
  - Make sure that it is relevant to the question stem
  - A further chain of XYZ reasoning with context is also required

However, the space taken up by Traffic Light lollies on display stands may be better used. Popular products such as Candy Necklaces with potential for sales growth should use the space. Losing out on sales of more popular products because of a lack of display space would reduce cash inflows. Money spent on promoting these items would be wasted.

A relevant counterpoint with context

A clear chain of reasoning

Step 4

- Repeat steps two and three with a further point and counterpoint

Traffic Light lollies may be a key part of Bon Bon's original product range and, therefore, an important part of its brand heritage. They may be an item that customers expect to see and removing them from the heritage sweets product portfolio may attract criticism. This may impact on Bon Bon's ability to persuade new giftshops to stock their products. These retailers could worry that other valued products may be withdrawn and purchase from alternative suppliers, reducing Bon Bons' revenue.

However, Traffic Light Lollies may be especially popular as a low-price option within Bon Bons' range. Parents may buy affordable options for their children rather than spending large amounts on other Bon Bons products. Earning at least some revenue is better than nothing, as it could contribute to covering fixed costs, even if a profit isn't made.

Another suitable point

Some context provided

A detailed chain of reasoning

Another relevant counterpoint

A chain of reasoning that is contextualised and demonstrates good understanding

Step 5

- In your final paragraph, you need to make a supported judgement

strength and relevance

- A decision is required, along with the main reasons for your choice
  - Are there any context-specific reasons for your choice?
  - Do you have all of the information required to make a reliable recommendation?
  - Does your answer depend on any internal or external factors?

- Try to broaden your reflection by considering factors such as
  - Whether your decision would be different in the long term
  - The views of different stakeholders
  - The contribution your decision may make to achieving business aims and objectives.

As long as they do not incur extra costs or take up production time here is little harm in continuing to sell Traffic Light Lollies and I recommend that they do so. There is a chance that the market for small treats may grow again. Retro products often move in and out of fashion and they may provide a cheaper option than the rest of the range, increasing the number of sales. However, if these perishable goods do sell in small volumes there is a chance that stockists are left with out-of-date stock which cannot be sold. These are likely to be returned to Bon Bons and refunds issued. This increases Bon Bons' costs, if this is a frequent occurrence Bon Bons may have little choice other than to withdraw the product, as is often the case with dog products.

Some judgement

Context supports the judgement

Weighing up points made in analysis

A detailed counter-argumement with good context

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